

# Research Statement

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## Summary

My research uses large-scale experiments and surveys to understand how people form beliefs about the economy, politics, and society, and how those beliefs translate into economic behavior. Four agendas organize this work. First, I study how narratives and stories shape belief formation and the transmission of information. Second, in the area of behavioral macroeconomics and labor, I examine how households, firms, and workers form expectations about the macroeconomy and the labor market, and how those expectations shape their economic choices. Third, I examine collective traps in markets for network goods such as social media, developing new tools to measure welfare when consumption imposes externalities on non-users. Fourth, a growing strand of my work uses artificial intelligence both as a tool to study economic behavior and as an instrument to address social problems at scale — from customizing the news people consume to motivating reductions in harmful social media use. Beyond these agendas, my work extends to the economics of mental health and to the drivers of political activism, and includes methodological contributions to survey and experimental measurement. While predominantly empirical, my research is closely connected to theory and is designed to disentangle mechanisms that observational data cannot separate.

## Learning from Stories and Narratives

The main strand of my work uses experiments to understand how narratives and stories shape individuals' beliefs and economic decisions. Narratives and storytelling pervade our lives: stories about immigration, welfare fraud, entrepreneurship, and inflation are abundant in the mass media and have been shown to affect important economic and political behaviors. My papers study narratives in the context of political expression, consumer decisions, labor markets, investment decisions, and macroeconomic phenomena. I ask not only whether narratives shape belief formation and behavior, but also which mechanisms make stories so powerful. My recent work focuses on how memory mechanisms underpin the persuasive advantage of stories over statistics, how information and explanations mutate as they are transmitted from person to person, why false stories continue to shape beliefs even after being corrected, and how narratives in the mass media and in political debate shape perceptions and behavior.

A first set of papers examines the memory mechanisms that determine the effectiveness of stories relative to statistics. Because the stories circulating in mass media are often highly selected and unrepresentative of reality at large, they have the potential to distort beliefs. In “Stories, Statistics, and Memory” (with Thomas Graeber and Florian Zimmermann, *Quarterly Journal of Economics*), we examine whether the extent of forgetting differs between stories and statistics. In controlled online experiments, we show that the effect of information on beliefs decays rapidly and exhibits a pronounced story–statistic gap: the average impact of stories on beliefs fades by 33% over the course of a day, but by 73% for statistics. Consistent with a model of similarity and interference in memory, prompting contextual associations with statistics improves recall. A series of mechanism experiments

shows that the story–statistic gap is primarily driven by the lower similarity of stories to interfering information. Our findings highlight the power of stories in mass media and inform the design of effective information campaigns.

Stories do not only need to be remembered — they also need to be passed on. To understand how qualitative information mutates through the process of human transmission, we conduct large-scale experiments in “The Transmission of Reliable and Unreliable Information” (with Thomas Graeber and Shakked Noy, accepted, *Quarterly Journal of Economics*). In our experiments, we pay participants to listen to audio recordings containing economic forecasts and to accurately transmit the information through voice messages. Other participants listen to an original or a transmitted recording before stating incentivized beliefs. Across various transmitter incentive schemes, a forecast's reliability is lost in transmission at a far higher rate than the forecast's level: reliable and unreliable information, once filtered through transmission, affect listener beliefs similarly. Mechanism experiments show that information about reliability is not perceived as less relevant or harder to transmit — it is simply less likely to come to mind during transmission.

Transmission often takes the form of explanations. In “Explanations” (with Thomas Graeber and Constantin Schesch), we study the role of explanations in the spread of truths and falsehoods across 15 financial reasoning tasks. We pay participants to record explanations for each of their answers, yielding over 6,900 unique verbal explanations. A separate group of participants either only observes an orator's choice or additionally listens to their explanation before making their own choice. Listening to explanations improves choice accuracy, but the effect is asymmetric: explanations enable the spread of truths, yet do not curb the contagion of falsehoods. We extract every argument provided in the explanations alongside a large collection of speech features, revealing the nature of financial reasoning on each topic. Explanations for truths contain higher-quality arguments and are systematically richer than explanations for falsehoods. These content differences in the supply of explanations account for two thirds of the differential effect and far outweigh the influence of orator and receiver characteristics.

The contagion of falsehoods raises the question of why false information is so sticky. In “Learning from False Stories” (with Robin Musolff and Florian Zimmermann), we study why false information continues to shape beliefs even after it is retracted or corrected. Using incentivized online experiments, we document a qualitative residue in learning from false information: false quantitative signals generate little to no belief updating once discredited, whereas false stories leave a substantial residual impact on beliefs. The effect is robust across many design variants. Replacing evaluative stories with more neutral versions eliminates the residue, showing that the valence of the qualitative information is central. We provide direct evidence that false stories increase mental simulation — measured through self-reports and through valence extracted from speech recordings — and that respondents are more confident in the beliefs they form after false stories than after false statistics, despite being further from the rational benchmark. The residue even appears among respondents who report not having been influenced by the story, consistent with stories shaping beliefs partly below conscious awareness.

Narratives also play a growing role in mass media, especially on opinion programs, which often convey conflicting narratives about reality. In “Opinions as Facts” (with Leonardo Bursztyjn, Aakaash Rao and David Yanagizawa-Drott, *Review of Economic Studies*), we first

document that people have a high demand for opinion shows relative to straight news programs, even when incentivized to learn facts. We then examine the consequences of diverging narratives between opinion programs in a high-stakes setting: the early stages of the COVID-19 pandemic in the United States. We find stark differences in the adoption of preventative behaviors among viewers of the two most popular opinion programs — both on the same network — which adopted opposing narratives about the threat posed by the pandemic. Areas with greater relative viewership of the program downplaying the threat experienced a greater number of COVID-19 cases and deaths. Our evidence suggests that opinion programs may distort important beliefs and behaviors by disseminating powerful narratives.

Popular narratives also pervade political debate, where potentially controversial opinions are rationalized by arguments. In “Justifying Dissent” (with Leonardo Bursztyn, Georgy Egorov, Ingar Haaland and Aakaash Rao, *Quarterly Journal of Economics*), we examine the hypothesis that narratives increase the public expression of dissent by providing “social cover” for voicing otherwise-stigmatized positions. Motivated by a simple theoretical framework, we experimentally show that liberals are more willing to post a tweet opposing the movement to defund the police, are seen as less prejudiced, and face lower social sanctions when their tweet implies they had first read credible scientific evidence supporting their position. Analogous experiments with conservatives demonstrate that the same mechanisms facilitate anti-immigrant expression. Our findings highlight both the power of rationales and their limitations in enabling dissent, and shed light on phenomena such as social movements, political correctness, propaganda, and anti-minority behavior.

## **Behavioral Macroeconomics and Labor**

A second agenda, closely connected to the first, studies expectation formation in macroeconomics and labor markets: how households, firms, and workers form beliefs about the economy, and how those beliefs shape consumption, investment, and labor market decisions. This work combines large representative surveys of households, firms, and experts with experiments and, increasingly, with macroeconomic theory.

In “Narratives about the Macroeconomy” (with Peter Andre, Ingar Haaland, Mirko Wiederholt and Johannes Wohlfart, *Review of Economic Studies*), we provide evidence on narratives about the macroeconomy — the stories people tell to explain macroeconomic phenomena — in the context of a historic surge in inflation. We measure economic narratives in open-ended survey responses and represent them as Directed Acyclic Graphs. Applying this approach in surveys with more than 10,000 U.S. households and 100 academic experts, we document three main findings. First, households' narratives are strongly heterogeneous and coarser than experts' narratives, focus more on the supply side than on the demand side, and often feature politically loaded explanations. Second, households' narratives strongly shape their inflation expectations, which we demonstrate with descriptive survey data and a series of experiments. Third, an experiment varying news consumption shows that the media is an important source of narratives. Our findings demonstrate the relevance of narratives for understanding macroeconomic expectation formation.

This paper builds on earlier work on mental models of the macroeconomy. In “Subjective Models of the Macroeconomy: Evidence from Experts and Representative Samples” (with Peter Andre, Carlo Pizzinelli and Johannes Wohlfart, *Review of Economic Studies*), we study

people's subjective models of the macroeconomy and shed light on their attentional foundations. We measure beliefs about the effects of macroeconomic shocks on unemployment and inflation, providing respondents with identical information about the parameters of the shocks and previous realizations of macroeconomic variables. Within samples of 6,500 U.S. households and 1,500 experts, beliefs are widely dispersed — even about the directional effects of shocks — and there are large differences in average beliefs between households and experts. Part of this disagreement arises because respondents think of different propagation channels, in particular demand- versus supply-side mechanisms. We provide evidence on the role of associative memory in driving heterogeneity in thoughts and forecasts: contextual cues and prior experiences shape which propagation channels individuals retrieve and thereby which forecasts they make. Our findings offer a new perspective on the widely documented disagreement in macroeconomic expectations.

Mental models also play an important role in the labor market, where misperceptions can be very costly. In “Worker Beliefs about Outside Options” (with Simon Jäger, Nina Roussille and Benjamin Schoefer, *Quarterly Journal of Economics*), we examine the accuracy of workers' beliefs about their outside options. We document that workers wrongly anchor these beliefs on their current wage; in particular, workers at low-wage firms underestimate wages elsewhere. We establish this anchoring bias by comparing representative survey data on worker beliefs in Germany with measures of actual outside options in linked administrative labor market data. Using both descriptive survey data and an information experiment, we then demonstrate that beliefs about outside options shape intended labor market behaviors. In an equilibrium model, we show that anchoring can give rise to monopsony and labor market segmentation. Taken together, our model and evidence highlight that misperceptions are pervasive, have allocative consequences, and are a plausible source of monopsony power.

Beyond the papers described above, this agenda includes “Attention to the Macroeconomy” (with Sebastian Link, Andreas Peichl, Oliver Pfäuti and Johannes Wohlfart, conditionally accepted, *Quarterly Journal of Economics*), which studies when and why economic agents pay attention to macroeconomic conditions; “Macro Theory with Measured Expectations” (with Ralph Luetticke, Mirko Wiederholt and Johannes Wohlfart), which integrates experimentally measured expectations into general equilibrium models to quantify the effects of monetary policy; “Home Price Expectations and Spending” (with Felix Chopra and Johannes Wohlfart, *American Economic Review*), which provides field-experimental evidence that home price expectations causally affect household spending; “Uncertainty and Information Acquisition” (with Heiner Mikosch, Samad Sarferaz and Johannes Wohlfart, *American Economic Journal: Macroeconomics*), which shows that uncertainty drives the acquisition of macroeconomic information by firms and households; “Information Frictions Among Firms and Households” (with Sebastian Link, Andreas Peichl and Johannes Wohlfart, *Journal of Monetary Economics*), which documents that firms are systematically better informed about the macroeconomy than households; and “How Do Expectations About the Macroeconomy Affect Personal Expectations and Behavior?” (with Johannes Wohlfart, *Review of Economics and Statistics*), which traces how aggregate expectations feed into personal economic expectations and consumption. Together, this work shows that measuring subjective beliefs — and the attention, memory, and narratives behind them — is central to understanding macroeconomic and labor market outcomes.

## **Collective Traps**

A third agenda studies collective traps in product markets. Many modern products — social media above all — derive their value from network effects, and their adoption imposes spillovers on non-users. In such markets, individual adoption decisions can trap consumers in equilibria they would collectively prefer to escape: large shares of users continue to consume products they wish did not exist. My co-authors and I develop new tools to measure welfare and define markets in these settings, and study the implications for market power, regulation, and policy.

In “When Product Markets Become Collective Traps: The Case of Social Media” (with Leonardo Bursztyn, Benjamin Handel and Rafael Jiménez-Durán, *American Economic Review*), we propose a new methodology for measuring welfare in the presence of consumption spillovers to non-users. We show that, in the presence of such spillovers, standard measures that take aggregate consumption as given fail to appropriately capture welfare. We propose a new welfare measure that accounts for these consumption spillovers and apply it to estimate the consumer surplus of two popular social media platforms, TikTok and Instagram. In large-scale, incentivized experiments with college students, we show that while the standard welfare measure suggests a large and positive surplus, our measure indicates a negative surplus, with a large share of active users deriving negative utility. We also shed light on the drivers of consumption spillovers to non-users and show that, in this setting, the “fear of missing out” plays an important role. Our framework and estimates highlight the possibility of product market traps, in which large shares of consumers are trapped in an inefficient equilibrium and would prefer the product not to exist.

In closely related work, “Measuring Markets for Network Goods” (with Leonardo Bursztyn, Matthew Gentzkow, Rafael Jiménez-Durán, Aaron Leonard and Filip Milojević, accepted, *Review of Economic Studies*), we develop a method to define markets and measure substitution patterns when goods have network effects — a central challenge for antitrust analysis, where substitution depends on changes in network size. In an incentivized experiment conducted amid high uncertainty about a potential U.S. TikTok ban, we compare how the valuations of other social apps change under individual versus collective deactivations of TikTok. Valuations of alternative apps rise more in response to a collective ban than to an individual deactivation, and the two designs can even yield qualitatively different conclusions about which goods are substitutes. Standard, individual-level demand estimates can therefore badly mislead market definition for network goods.

In “Tipping Points and Australia's Social Media Ban” (with Leonardo Bursztyn, Angela Duckworth, Rafael Jiménez-Durán, Aaron Leonard, Filip Milojević and Cass Sunstein), we study the world's first national ban on social media use for children under 16, implemented in December 2025. Surveying 14–15-year-olds four months after implementation, we find that fewer than one in three complied, and that teenagers report needing roughly two of three peers to comply before they would comply themselves — a classic tipping-point structure. Because early compliers were perceived as less popular, compliance eroded rapidly, falling to about one in twenty within two months. The results suggest that bans alone are unlikely to reduce adolescent social media use and must be paired with individual incentives and social-norm interventions.

In “Non-User Utility and Market Power: The Case of Smartphones” (with Leonardo Bursztyn, Rafael Jiménez-Durán, Aaron Leonard and Filip Milojević), we show that firms can build market power not only by raising the utility of their users but also by lowering the

utility of non-users. Studying Apple's “green bubble” — which visibly marks messages sent from Android phones — we document in experiments with U.S. college students that green bubbles are widely stigmatized: most iPhone and Android users would prefer they not exist, iPhone users are willing to pay to avoid sending them, and students become substantially more likely to choose Android when green bubbles are expected to be removed. The paper illustrates how deliberately imposed non-user externalities can entrench a dominant platform.

In “Social Dynamics of AI Adoption in Parents' Educational Decisions” (with Leonardo Bursztyn, Alex Imas, Rafael Jiménez-Durán and Aaron Leonard, accepted, *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences*), we study how society adopts AI itself. Examining parents' decisions about AI tools in education, we find that demand rises sharply with the share of other teenagers using the technology — social forces raise willingness to pay for AI by more than 60%. Providing information about the potential harms of unstructured AI use lowers parents' beliefs about AI's merits and increases their support for banning AI in schools, yet does not reduce their own demand. Because social information barely moves beliefs about quality, the effects appear to operate through social pressure rather than social learning: parents adopt out of fear of falling behind even as they favor restrictions.

In “Non-User Externalities” (with Leonardo Bursztyn, Jan Fasnacht, Benjamin Handel, Rafael Jiménez-Durán, Aaron Leonard, Filip Milojević and Cass Sunstein), we develop a unified framework for non-user externalities — the benefits or harms that a product's adoption imposes differentially on non-users versus users — and distinguish them from network effects and from classic externalities such as pollution. The key distinction is that those harmed by a classic externality cannot escape it by joining the activity, whereas those harmed by a negative non-user externality can, simply by becoming users. This escape route expands the harm borne by the remaining non-users, generating cascade dynamics that can culminate in product market traps, in which individuals would prefer the product not to exist yet adopt it rather than remain non-users. Using new survey evidence spanning 25 product markets, we show that negative non-user externalities are pervasive, that their underlying mechanisms differ systematically across products, and that they generate adoption pressure on non-users. We then trace the implications for welfare analysis, firms' strategic incentives, and market structure, and discuss policy responses ranging from design regulation to collective coordination mechanisms.

## **Using AI to Address Social Problems**

A fourth, growing agenda uses artificial intelligence not only as a measurement tool but as an instrument to address social problems at scale. AI makes it possible to personalize and standardize interventions — customized news, structured conversations — in ways previously infeasible, and to evaluate them in large field experiments.

In “News Customization with AI” (with Felix Chopra, Ingar Haaland, Fabian Roeben and Vanessa Sticher, revise and resubmit, *Review of Economic Studies*), we ask whether letting people customize the news can reduce the persistent mismatch between what outlets supply — optimized for engagement — and what readers actually want. In an AI-powered news app, users can adjust features such as writing complexity or the amount of opinion while holding the underlying news event fixed, unbundling presentation from coverage. Using rich consumption data from large-scale field experiments, we document substantial

heterogeneity in preferences: while some users demand politically aligned news, the large majority persistently prefer less opinionated, more fact-driven coverage. Customization improves the match between the news consumed and stated preferences and raises news satisfaction.

In “Evaluating Behavioral Interventions at Scale with AI” (with Felix Chopra, Ingar Haaland and Nicolas Roeber, revise and resubmit, *The Economic Journal*), we use AI interviewers to deliver and rigorously compare behavioral interventions aimed at reducing social media use. In an experiment with 2,719 social media users, participants were randomized to a control conversation or to one of three AI-led protocols: two motivational-interviewing protocols eliciting self-persuasion (a change-focus and a decisional-balance protocol) and a direct-persuasion protocol offering advice and information. Because an AI interviewer delivers each protocol identically, the design overcomes a long-standing obstacle: standardizing and scaling conversational interventions that are infeasible to randomize with human interviewers. All three interventions significantly increased motivation to change and the perceived costs of social media use, with change-focused self-persuasion producing the largest effects.

## **Beliefs, Stigma, and Mental Health**

A further strand of my work studies the economics of mental health, connecting the agenda on beliefs to health behavior and wellbeing. In “Income Shocks and Suicides: Causal Evidence from Indonesia” (with Cornelius Christian and Lukas Hensel, *Review of Economics and Statistics*), we show that negative agricultural income shocks causally increase suicide rates and provide evidence that cash transfer programs can mitigate this effect, highlighting economic conditions as an important determinant of mental health. In “Misperceived Effectiveness and the Demand for Psychotherapy” (with Peter Schwardmann and Egon Tripodi, *Journal of Public Economics*), we document — in a sample of over 1,800 depressed individuals — that concerns about effectiveness are top of mind when people consider therapy, that the average respondent underestimates the effectiveness of psychotherapy, and that correcting this misperception increases the incentivized willingness to pay for therapy. In “Depression Stigma” (with Peter Schwardmann and Egon Tripodi, *Journal of Public Economics*), we introduce a new measure of perceived depression stigma and show that most depressed individuals overestimate the stigma associated with depression. Strikingly, and in contrast to prior correlational evidence, lowering perceived stigma reduces the demand for psychotherapy: the information makes respondents more optimistic about their future mental health and thereby lowers their perceived need for treatment. Together, these papers show that beliefs — about treatment effectiveness and about the judgments of others — are central to help-seeking behavior.

## **Political Activism**

Connected to my work on political expression, a series of natural field experiments studies what motivates political activists, conducted with Anselm Hager, Lukas Hensel, Johannes Hermle and Andreas Stegmann. In “Political Activists as Free-Riders” (*The Economic Journal*), we show that activists reduce their own campaign effort when they learn that many fellow party members are active — behaving like free-riders in the private provision of a public good. Consistent with this, activism responds little to instrumental considerations such as the perceived competitiveness of elections (“Does Party Competition Affect Political

Activism?”, *The Journal of Politics*; “Political Activists are Not Driven by Instrumental Motives”, accepted, *British Journal of Political Science*), while giving party members voice in strategic decisions raises their engagement (“Voice and Political Engagement”, *Review of Economics and Statistics*). In “Group Size and Protest Mobilization across Movements and Countermovements” (*American Political Science Review*), we use field experiments around large demonstrations to study how beliefs about turnout shape protest participation on both sides of a contested issue.

## Methodological Work

A final strand of my work develops methods for survey and experimental measurement. One key challenge for all experiments other than natural field experiments is experimenter demand effects. In “Measuring and Bounding Experimenter Demand” (with Jonathan de Quidt and Johannes Haushofer, *American Economic Review*), we propose a technique for assessing the robustness of findings from experiments and surveys to demand effects. The core idea is that by deliberately inducing demand in a structured way, we can bound its influence. We present a model in which participants respond to their beliefs about the researcher's objectives; bounds are obtained by manipulating those beliefs with “demand treatments.” We apply the method to eleven classic tasks and estimate bounds averaging 0.13 standard deviations, suggesting that typical demand effects are modest. We also show how to compute demand-robust treatment effects and how to structurally estimate the model.

My co-authors and I have also reviewed best practices for information provision experiments. In “Designing Information Provision Experiments” (with Ingar Haaland and Johannes Wohlfart, *Journal of Economic Literature*), we survey the emerging literature using information provision experiments in economics and discuss applications in macroeconomics, finance, political economy, public economics, labor economics, and health economics. We also discuss design considerations and provide best-practice recommendations on how to (i) measure beliefs, (ii) design the information intervention, (iii) measure belief updating, (iv) deal with potential confounds, such as experimenter demand effects, and (v) recruit respondents using online panels. The review covers methodological innovations, such as obfuscated follow-up designs, that we developed in earlier work on narratives about the labor market impact of immigration (Haaland and Roth, 2020) and about the drivers of racial inequalities (Haaland and Roth, 2023).

In the review “Understanding Economic Behavior Using Open-Ended Survey Data” (with Ingar Haaland, Stefanie Stantcheva and Johannes Wohlfart, *Journal of Economic Literature*), we survey the emerging literature using open-ended questions. We first provide an overview of studies in political economy, macroeconomics, finance, labor economics, and behavioral economics that have employed such measurement. We then describe different ways of measuring the considerations that are on top of people's minds, provide an overview of methods to annotate and analyze such data, and discuss applications including the measurement of motives, mental models, narratives, attention, information transmission, and recall. The review highlights the potential of open-ended questions for gaining a deeper understanding of the mechanisms underlying observed choices and expectations.

A distinctive methodological feature of my recent experimental work is the use of speech recordings as a source of data. In “The Transmission of Reliable and Unreliable Information,” participants pass on economic information through voice messages, allowing



us to study what survives — and what is lost — in naturalistic communication. In “Explanations,” we collect over 6,900 verbal explanations and annotate them at scale, extracting every argument alongside a rich set of speech features. In “Learning from False Stories,” we use the valence extracted from speech recordings to measure mental simulation. Audio data preserve dimensions of communication that written responses miss — spontaneity, emphasis, and affect — and modern AI tools make it possible to transcribe, annotate, and analyze such data at scale. I view the combination of naturalistic speech data and large-scale experiments as a promising frontier for measuring cognition and communication in economics.

In the review “The Social Desirability Atlas” (with Leonardo Bursztyn, Ingar Haaland and Nicolas Roever, accepted, *Journal of Political Economy Microeconomics*), we take stock of social desirability bias — the tendency of survey respondents to misreport sensitive attitudes and behaviors in order to appear more socially acceptable — which poses a pervasive threat to the validity of survey data. We synthesize the empirical evidence on the prevalence and magnitude of the bias across domains and critically assess commonly used mitigation strategies, highlighting how they can backfire by creating confusion or inadvertently heightening the perceived sensitivity of a question. We provide practical guidance for selecting the most suitable tools for a given research context and examine how social desirability bias can distort estimated treatment effects.

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